

Being online allows us to connect with people who are far away and share content, however this participation in the virtual world, since it has intensified, has led to anthropological changes. Studies highlight a direct correlation between the use of social media and the emergence of cognitive disorders, that were previously less spread.

When is the moment when everything started? During the pandemic, thousands of people began to share their lives on social media, blurring the boundary between private and public life. Lockdown and social separation deprived of one defining aspect of the human existence, being with others. The natural need for connection and closeness, at risk of falling into the void, created by the absence of others, using net as a survival tool, pushing us to transform every aspect of our lives into a public performance. We offer a representation of ourselves, evoking a theatrical language where representing something differs from living it directly. It turns us in directors, designers, who must perform a role. Removed from the direct gaze of others, we're able to decide what to show and what to keep hidden, constructing a digital identity deliberately. Confined within our profiles, we've bend to rules set by the platforms, encouraging us to share our intimate aspect of our lives, to get likes. To make content more appealing and engaging, we're sharing with strangers our most private things. While on the other side this turns into digital performances, they're no more than fragments, and at the same time an emotional distance has emerged, preventing to perceive the real weight of stories behind the screen. The more stories are shared, the less participation we have. From empathy, little by little we're starting to feeling difference.

Our need for recognition must become a content online, as capitalism works by turning everything it touches into a commodity. When capitalistic markets have placed roots into the net, capitalism has begun to exploit everything, including children and disabled people, transforming them into content worth millions of views. It also allowed unethical individuals to profit from their exposure, with cyber crimes.

It is undeniable that platforms have changed dramatically the way we communicate, breaking down our cultural careers. They've enabeld the institution of social movements, creating spaces for minorities, and fostering network of solidarity, extending beyond the physical boundaries.

There's however, a less visible but equally important side, made up of emotional manipulation, social pressure, and competitive dynamics enhanced by platforms. Social network are not neutral, they're specifically designed to capture our attention for as long as possible, in order to target. Confined within our bubbles,

our identity (shielded by genuine otherness), we no longer exercise critical skills. Our thinking and identity become radicalised and polarised, feeding a culture based on appearance, and the pursuit of consensus rather than the pursuit of sensus.

The individualism dominating digital culture is not accidental, rather the result of a mindset rooted in the economy. We will see how individualism and completion form the bases of today's labor market. Solidarity, collaboration, mutual aid, are not celebrated, instead merit, determination and hard work are placed at the center. Success depends exclusively on individual efforts. The myth of self sufficiency and meritocracy forces us to become entrepreneur of ourselves. With the emergence of platforms, millions of users have embraced this code, building versions of themselves designed to attract attention, turning themselves as products to be displayed and sold.

This is the point where capitalism reaches its peak. Previously, there was this dialectic between a master and a slave, where the slave aspired to free himself from domination, while digital technocapitalism makes us both masters and slaves at the same times, we're employers and workers of ourselves. The rules imposed by capitalism has the relationship of exploitation directed towards ourselves, disguised as aspiration.

We create these personal narratives, designed to attract attention of specific audience (like friends). To be recognizable online, we must be transparent, exposing ourselves forcefully, fitting into categories making us identifiable. We're encouraged to focus on a specific identity and develop it. We need to turn ourselves into products to be consumed between one scroll and another. Likes becomes measures of our values. What matters is no longer who we are in essence, but how we're perceived. Yesterday we've seen the difference between appearance and show. Our values is not intrinsic anymore, but is tied to our ability to perform.

Everything started in 2003 with Zuckerberg, founded the site "hot or not". He broke into servers of several universities fraternities, downloading student photos without consent, creating this website where everyone could compare two pictures, and vote for who they find more attractive. This revealed his ruthlessness in abandoning privacy of students involved. With the increase of popularity, people started uploading their photos to get a sign of approval. Facebook managed to exploit the human fragility and our anxiety of being seen and appreciated. With this new system of rapid interaction, social anxiety was relieved, soon becoming a vortex of approval seeking.

Just like the experiment with mices, human beings adopt repetitive behaviour to

receive social rewards, through a small amount of dopamine, responsible for pleasure.

Reward is not always guaranteed, and this uncertainty makes this experience more powerful.

Users sharing private content on social medias don't know when and where they'll receive appreciation, turning it into a real addiction. Being online has become familiar for us, and we've learnt that certain types of contents turns more attention. We allowed facebook to collect a lot of data about us. Thanks to this contribution, a new economic model emerged, with large companies no longer producing software to sell, instead users' data. Therefore, users by posting content and interacting, enabled platforms to collect and resell that data to third parties. Some years later, Zuckenberg acquired instagram, refining his surveillance system more effective. What is the difference between Facebook and Instagram? With the spread of the latter, communication shifts from a model based 50/50 on images/words, on a one celebrating visual culture. In this competition, ? identified an opportunity, shaping the desire of general public.

Online, not only celebrities have space, but also new previously unknown figures, who've managed to build a following, cultivating a direct relationships with others. Requirements with success was, in one hand, adapting to standards imposed by standard, and in the other the challenge was appearing genuine and authentic, sincerely interested in followers' lives and opinions. We can observe that what is consumed is not just the product promoted by influencers, but is the influencer itself that is consumed.

For a long time, advertisers have tried to humanize brands, and now it's people that brands themselves.

Influencers began to monetize their following, by integrating into content in a narrative way, not being explicitly declared, but blending commercial suggestions into a set of informal advice. Narrative markets aims at product placement, shaping our consumption desire, creating a grey area between narrative and selling.

At a certain point, some platforms stopped showing feeds on a chronological order, rather in a personalised feed for users. This personalisation, marked as improved online experience, was actually conceived the goal of keeping the users on the app for a longer time, increasing the number of advertisements that can be viewed.

It's clear that algorithms are not truly democratic, but rather they reinforce specific power dynamics, as users who manage to create successful content often comes from privileged social context allowing them to invest money in their personal brand. Second, as algorithms amplifies discrimination by granting greater

visibility to profiles. Gaming, technology and politics for men, fashion, beauty and personal relationships for women. Creators themselves learned and internalised the algorithmic logic, constantly modifying the digital identity, producing increasingly impactful content to maintain visibility. With the rise of TikTok, another transformation occurred. First of all as the number of content creators has grown exponentially, and content has become faster and easier to consume. The refined feeds of Instagram have lost their appeal, in favour of entertainment offered by ordinary people presenting themselves authentically. However, this is nothing more than a response to a new market demand, which wants to see his reflection into something more relatable. Visibility is no longer achieved through perfect images, but also through raw contents.

The pandemic opened the door to new aesthetics, the one of artificial simplicity in scrolling. Platforms give a disorienting experience. The goal is not only to understand users' preference, but also shaping their interests. Therefore, content selection on TikTok is designed to maximize interaction.

However, we must ask what remains authentic if complexity and private emotions like pain and grief are reduced. If every emotion becomes replicable, they lose their original intensity, and we should ask what happens in this stereotypification of feelings, what are the consequences for individuals.

In this constant race for visibility, TikTok ends up rewarding the most shocking content, pushing people to expose even the most intimate and painful aspects of their existence. Death, suffering and joy are emptied of their deeper meaning, in order to be consumed. Individuals are deprived of the possibility of creating meaningful stories.

On the net, some specific behaviour emerges, and despite being a significant part of online existence, they're often poorly regulated, and this forces us to navigate into an anomic world without protection (lawless world).

Let's now consider three emblematic phenomena that can picture what we've said so far: the first one is charenting (??), the second is the capitalism of compassion, and the other one the capitalism of pain. Charenting (parenting and caring) consists in exposing children that are generally often minors on platforms, making them the main subject of the content being shared. This practice, which initially didn't reveal its problematic aspect, has later proven to carry risks. There is a first problematic dimension, that images of children may be altered and used to fuel the child pornography market. What is most disturbing is that when parents notice higher engagement in videos where children are eating an ice cream, or taking a bath, will lead them to produce more content in that direction, exposing their children.

We have a society lacking social support system, and is dominated by individualistic objective.

This phenomena reveals its nature as a system of capture, shaped by the market. While the welfare state has lead to children being able to go to school instead of working when young, but childhood is transformed into a performative reality, therefore into a job. Children may be forced to repeat the same scene dozens of times (for a video), learning a script, and sacrificing time which should be devoted by playing or studying.

Moreover, in the future, these children celebrities will have to come to terms with parallel identities over which they have no control, remaining accessible to everyone, raising the issue of secondary contentification: once the content is uploaded, it's almost impossible to stop it from circulating.

The second one is compassion capitalism: following the trend of spectacularization of pain, the phenomena of publishing content showing people suffering, victims of abuse, has become increasingly widespread. Typically this content is filmed secretly, with the intention to monetize vulnerability, turning it into entertainment. Misery shows, in which ordinary people receive gifts and aids from sponsors in exchange to tell their tragic stories. Here we can see the message: consumer goods can solve problems. The media educate the public in believing into redemptive power of consumerism.

At times, quierism (??) becomes a power dynamic between observer and observed, where access to others life becomes a form of intrusion. On twitch, we have marathons lasting for days in order to get subscriptions, with the longer people subscribe, the longer they will stay online. We can also observe the phenomena of users paying to watch streamers humiliate themselves, or undergo inflicted pain. We also have the good samaritans of the web, but their actions are not acts of pure generosity, but strategic choices aimed at maximizing views and profits. The primary purpose is not to help people, but glorify acts of the creators. This acts are not truly altruistic, as they lack disinterest and gratuitness, driven by profit and self celebration.

We also have pain/suffering capitalism. During the pandemic, social media became a way to seek lightness, or attempt to process pain outside of our solitude, and the content produced within this pain capitalism, depicting death, may appear grotesque, but for those participating it could represent a spontaneous form of sharing.

As these practices evolved, the narration of grief became the defining elements justifying the presence on social medias, with some profiles continued to center the narrative on diseases, normalising grief.

Today, a number of platforms emerged offering support to those going through difficult times, but they're not for free, and even pain becomes a product, being a service.

Technocapitalism uses immaterial as a merch.

In essence, sharing aspects of life can create networks, however how these platforms work, risks of commodifying suffering, turning into a continuous flow of entertainment.